This chunky vegetable soup owes much of its appeal to the robust nature of homemade harissa, which can be made in advance and stored in the refrigerator.

harissa and chickpea soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 25 MINS **COOK** 45 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

for the harissa paste
1 red bell pepper
2 tbsp olive oil
½ tsp coriander seeds
2 tsp cumin seeds
1 tsp caraway seeds
2 tsp tomato purée
3 garlic cloves, coarsely chopped
4 red chiles, seeds removed, coarsely chopped
1 tsp smoked paprika
juice of 1 lemon

for the soup
1 tbsp olive oil
3½oz (100g) smoked pancetta, cubed
2 red onions, diced
1 potato, peeled and diced
3 celery ribs, diced
1 small fennel, thinly sliced
3 tbsp oregano leaves, chopped
1 x 14oz (400g) can chopped tomatoes
3¼ cups vegetable stock
1 x 14oz (400g) can chickpeas, drained
1 bay leaf

1 To make the harissa, rub the red bell pepper with olive oil and cook under the broiler for 10–15 minutes, turning frequently, until the skin is blackened and charred. Remove to a bowl, cover with plastic wrap, and let cool. Peel away the skin, discard the seeds, and coarsely chop the flesh.

2 Heat a small frying pan over low heat and roast the coriander, cumin, and caraway seeds for about a minute, stirring. Using a mortar and pestle, pound the spices to a powder. Transfer to a food processor and add the red bell pepper along with the tomato purée, garlic, red chiles, paprika, and lemon juice. Process until smooth, gradually adding the remaining olive oil.

3 To make the soup, heat the olive oil in a large saucepan and cook the pancetta until golden, then remove. Add the onion, potato, celery, fennel, and oregano to the pan. Cover and soften over low heat for 10 minutes. Stir in 1–2 tbsp of the harissa paste and the tomatoes and continue cooking for 5 minutes. Add the stock, pancetta, chickpeas, and bay leaf. Season well, and simmer in a half-covered pan for 20 minutes. Remove the bay leaf and serve.